

The Witherspoon Institute

Thomistic Seminar

Wednesday, July 29

Individual Happiness

Morning Session

Prof. Joseph Stenberg

Readings:

Summa theologiae I-II, q. 4-5

Thomas Aquinas

"Happiness"

Jean Porter

QUESTION 4

What is Required for Beatitude

Next we have to consider the things required for beatitude. And on this topic there are eight questions: (1) Is delight required for beatitude? (2) Is it the delighting or the seeing which is more central to beatitude? (3) Is comprehending required for beatitude? (4) Is rectitude of will required for beatitude? (5) Is the body required for man's beatitude? (6) Is the perfection of the body required for beatitude? (7) Are any exterior goods required for beatitude? (8) Is the company of friends required for beatitude?

Article 1

Is delight required for beatitude?

It seems that delight (*delectatio*) is not required for beatitude:

Objection 1: In *De Trinitate* 1 Augustine says, "The vision is faith's entire reward." But as is clear from the Philosopher in *Ethics* 1, it is beatitude that is the reward or payment for virtue. Therefore, nothing other than the vision alone is required for beatitude.

Objection 2: As the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 1, "Beatitude is a good that is sufficient by itself (*per se*)." But whatever stands in need of something else is not sufficient by itself. Therefore, since, as has been shown (q. 3, a. 8), the essence of beatitude consists in the act of seeing God, it seems that an act of delighting is not required for beatitude.

Objection 3: As *Ethics* 7 says, "The operation of happiness [read: beatitude] must be unimpeded." But as *Ethics* 6 says, delight impedes the intellect's action; for it undermines the judgment of prudence. Therefore, delight is not required for beatitude.

But contrary to this: In *Confessiones* 10 Augustine says that beatitude is "rejoicing in the truth (*gaudium de veritate*)."

I respond: There are four possible ways in which one thing is required for another:

In one way, it is required as a *precursor to* or *preparation for* (*praeambulum vel praeparatorium*) that thing, in the way that instruction (*disciplina*) is required for scientific knowledge.

In a second way, it is required in the sense that it *brings that thing to perfection* (*sicut perficiens aliquid*), in the way that a soul is required for a body's life.

In a third way, it is required as an *extrinsic aid*, in the way that friends are required for doing something.

In a fourth way, it is required as *something concomitant*, in the way that heat is said to be required for fire.

It is in this last way that delight is required for beatitude. For delight is caused by a desire's coming to rest in a good that has been attained. Hence, since beatitude is nothing other than the attaining of the highest good, beatitude cannot exist without a concomitant delight.

Reply to objection 1: By the very fact that a reward is given to someone, the will of the one who merits the reward comes to rest, and this is what it is to have delight. Thus, delight is included in the very notion of a reward's being given.

Reply to objection 2: The act of delighting is caused by the very act of seeing God. Therefore, he who sees God cannot 'stand in need' of delight.

Reply to objection 3: As *Ethics* 10 says, an act of delighting that is concomitant with an operation of the intellect strengthens that operation and does not impede it. For what we do with delight we do with more attentiveness and perseverance.

On the other hand, an extraneous act of delighting does impede the intellect's operation. It sometimes does this by distracting one's attention, since, as has been explained, we are more attentive to those things in which we take delight; and when we are intensely attentive to one thing, our attention is

necessarily withdrawn from anything else. But it also sometimes does this by contrariety, in the sense that a sensual delight that is contrary to reason impedes the judgment of prudence more than the judgment of the speculative intellect.

Article 2

Is the act of delighting more central to beatitude than the act of seeing?

It seems that the act of delighting (*delectatio*) is more central (*principalius*) to beatitude than the act of seeing (*visio*):

Objection 1: *Ethics* 10 says, “Delight is the perfection of an operation.” But the perfection is better than that which is perfected. Therefore, the act of delighting is more central (*potior*) than the intellect’s operation, i.e., the act of seeing.

Objection 2: What is more central (*potius*) is that for the sake of which something is desirable. But operations are desired for the sake of the delight they bring (*propter delectationem ipsarum*); hence, nature attaches delight to the operations necessary for conserving the individual and the species, so that these operations will not be neglected by animals. Therefore, in the case of beatitude the act of delighting is more central than the intellect’s operation, i.e., the act of seeing.

Objection 3: The act of seeing corresponds to faith, whereas the act of delighting (*delectatio*), i.e., the act of enjoying (*fruitio*), corresponds to charity. But as the Apostle says in 1 Corinthians 13:13, charity is greater than faith. Therefore, the act of delighting, i.e., the act of enjoying, is more central than the act of seeing.

But contrary to this: A cause is more central than its effect. But the act of seeing is a cause of the act of delighting. Therefore, the act of seeing is more central than the act of delighting.

I respond: The Philosopher poses this problem in *Ethics* 10 and leaves it unresolved.

However, if one considers the matter carefully, it must necessarily be the case that the intellect’s operation, which is the act of seeing, is more central than the act of delighting. For the act of delighting consists in the will’s coming to rest in a certain way (*consistit in quadam quietatione voluntatis*). But the will comes to rest in something only because of the goodness of the thing in which it comes to rest. Therefore, if the will comes to rest in some operation, then the will’s coming to rest proceeds from the operation’s goodness. But it is not the case that the will seeks the good for the sake of coming to rest; for if that were so, then the act of will itself would be the end—which is contrary to what was premised. Rather, the reason why it seeks to come to rest in the operation is that the operation is its good. Hence, it is clear that the very operation that the will comes to rest in is a more central good than is the will’s coming to rest therein.

Reply to objection 1: As the Philosopher says in the same place, “Delight perfects the operation in the way that comeliness perfects youth,” i.e., it follows upon youth. Hence, delight is a perfection that is concomitant with the act of seeing, and it is not a perfection in the sense that it makes the act of seeing to be perfect within its own species.

Reply to objection 2: Sentient apprehension does not attain to the general notion of the good; instead, it attains to some particular good that is pleasurable. And so in the case of the sentient appetite that exists in animals, operations are sought for the sake of pleasure (*propter delectationem*).

By contrast, the intellect apprehends the universal notion of the good, whose attainment is followed by delight. Hence, the intellect intends the good more centrally than the delight. And hence it is that God’s intellect, which instituted nature, attached the delights for the sake of the operations.

Now a thing should not be judged simply in accord with the order of the sentient appetite; instead, it should be judged in accord with the order of the intellective appetite.

Reply to objection 3: Charity does not seek the good it loves for the sake of delight; instead, its taking delight in an acquired good that it loves is consequent to it. And so it is not the act of delighting that is related to charity as an end, but instead the act of seeing, through which the end first becomes present to it.

Article 3

Is comprehending required for beatitude?

It seems that comprehending is not required for beatitude:

Objection 1: In *Ad Paulinum De Vivendo Deum* Augustine says, “To attain to God with the mind is great beatitude, but to comprehend Him is impossible.” Therefore, there is beatitude without comprehending.

Objection 2: Beatitude is a man’s perfection with respect to the intellective part [of his soul], in which, as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, qq. 79ff.), there are no powers other than the intellect and the will. But the intellect is sufficiently perfected by the act of seeing God (*per visionem Dei*), whereas the will is sufficiently perfected by the act of delighting in Him (*per delectationem in ipso*). Therefore, it is not the case that an act of comprehending is required as some sort of third thing.

Objection 3: Beatitude consists in an operation. But operations are specified by their objects. Now there are two general objects, viz., the true and the good, with the true corresponding to the act of seeing and the good corresponding to the act of delighting. Therefore, it is not the case that an act of comprehending is required as, so to speak, a third thing.

But contrary to this: In 1 Corinthians 9:24 the Apostle says, “Run in such a way as to comprehend (*ut comprehendatis*).” But spiritual running terminates in beatitude, as he himself says at the end of 2 Timothy (“I have fought the good fight, I have finished the course, I have kept the faith; as to the rest, there is laid up for me a crown of justice”). Therefore, comprehending is required for beatitude.

I respond: Since beatitude consists in attaining the ultimate end, what is required for beatitude has to be taken from man’s very ordering toward his end.

Now man is ordered toward his intelligible end partly through his intellect and partly through his will: through his *intellect*, insofar as there exists in the intellect beforehand an *imperfect cognition* of the end; and through his *will*, first through *love* (*per amorem*), which is the first mover of the will toward something, and, second, through a real relation of the lover to what is loved. There can be three such relations: (a) sometimes what is loved is present to the lover, and in that case what is loved is no longer sought after; (b) sometimes what is loved is not present but is impossible to attain, and in that case it is likewise not sought after; and (c) sometimes what is loved is possible to attain, but it is elevated beyond the ability of the one who seeks it (*est elevatum supra facilitatem adipiscentis*), so that it cannot be had immediately—and this is the relation of *the one who hopes to what he hopes for*, which is the only relation that induces the seeking of the end (*sola habitudo facit finis inquisitionem*).

Now there are certain elements in beatitude itself answering to the three things just noted. For the *perfect cognition* of the end answers to the *imperfect cognition*; the *presence of the end itself* answers to the *relation of hope*; and, as was explained above (a. 2), the *act of delighting* in the already present end follows upon the *love* (*consequitur dilectionem*).

And so for beatitude it is necessary for these three things to come together, viz., *the act of seeing* (*visio*), which is the perfect cognition of the intelligible end; *comprehending* (*comprehensio*), which implies the presence of the end; and the act of *delighting* or *enjoying* (*delectatio vel fructio*), which implies the lover’s coming to rest in what is loved.

Reply to objection 1: There are two senses of ‘comprehending’:

The first sense is the inclusion of what is comprehended in that which comprehends it, and in this sense whatever is comprehended by something finite is itself finite. Hence, in this sense God cannot be comprehended by any created intellect.

In the second sense ‘comprehending’ names nothing other than embracing a thing that is now had with its presence (*tentionem alicuius rei iam praesentialiter habitae*), as when someone who attains a thing is said to comprehend it when he is embracing it. And it is in this sense that comprehending is required for beatitude.

Reply to objection 2: Just as hope and love involve the will because the same will loves something and tends toward it when it is not had, so too comprehending and delighting involve the will because the same will possesses something and comes to rest in it.

Reply to objection 3: The comprehending is not an operation in addition to the seeing, but is instead a certain relation to the end once it is had. Hence, the very act of seeing, or the thing seen insofar as it is there with its presence, is the object of the comprehending.

Article 4

Is rectitude of will required for beatitude?

It seems that rectitude of will is not required for beatitude:

Objection 1: As has been explained (q. 3, a. 4), beatitude consists essentially in an operation of the intellect. But rectitude of will, through which men are called ‘clean’, is not required for the perfect operation of the intellect; for in *Recontrationes* Augustine says, “I do not approve of what I said in the prayer, ‘God, who does not will any but the clean to know the truth ...’. For it can be replied that many who are not clean also know many truths.” Therefore, rectitude of will is not required for beatitude.

Objection 2: What is prior does not depend on what is posterior to it. But the intellect’s operation is prior to the will’s operation. Therefore, beatitude, which is the perfect operation of the intellect, does not depend on rectitude of will.

Objection 3: What is ordered toward something as toward an end is not necessary once the end has been attained, e.g., a ship after it has arrived at the port. But rectitude of will, which exists through virtue, is ordered toward beatitude as toward an end. Therefore, once beatitude has been attained, rectitude of will is unnecessary.

But contrary to this: Matthew 5:8 says, “Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God.” And Hebrews 12:14 says, “Follow peace with all men, and holiness, without which no man shall see God.”

I respond: Rectitude of will is required for beatitude both as something antecedent to it and as something concomitant with it (*et antecedenter et concomitanter*).

Rectitude of will is required as *something antecedent* because it exists through an appropriate ordering toward the ultimate end. But the end is related to what is ordered toward the end in the way that form is related to matter. Hence, just as matter cannot attain to a form unless it is disposed in the right way for that form, so nothing attains an end unless it is ordered in the right way toward that end. And so no one can arrive at beatitude unless he has rectitude of will.

Rectitude of will is required as *something concomitant* because, as has been explained (q.3, a. 8), ultimate beatitude consists in seeing God’s essence, which is the very essence of goodness. And so the will of the one who is seeing God’s essence must love whatever he loves in relation to God (*sub ordine ad Deum*), just as the will of someone who is not seeing God must love whatever he loves in relation to the general notion he has of the good (*sub communi ratione boni quam novit*). And it is this very thing that gives the will rectitude (*quod facit voluntatem rectam*). Hence, it is clear that beatitude cannot exist

without a rectified will (*sine recta voluntate*).

Reply to objection 1: Augustine is talking about the cognition of a truth that is not the very essence of goodness.

Reply to objection 2: Every act of the will is preceded by some act of the intellect, and yet some acts of the will are prior to some acts of the intellect. For the will tends toward the final act of the intellect, which is beatitude. And so the right sort of inclination of the will is a prerequisite for beatitude in the way that the right sort of movement on the part of an arrow is a prerequisite for its striking the target.

Reply to objection 3: Not everything that is ordered toward an end ceases when the end is attained; rather, all that ceases is that which, like a movement, involves a notion of imperfection. Hence, the instruments of a movement are not necessary after it arrives at its end, but the right sort of ordering toward the end is necessary.

Article 5

Is the body required for beatitude?

It seems that the body is required for beatitude [or being blessed]:

Objection 1: The perfection of virtue and of grace presuppose the perfection of nature. But beatitude is the perfection of virtue and of grace. Now the soul without the body does not have the perfection of nature, since the body is by nature a part of a human nature, and every part is imperfect when separated from its whole. Therefore, the soul cannot be blessed (*beata*) without the body.

Objection 2: As was explained above (q. 3, a. 2), beatitude is a certain operation. But a perfect operation follows upon perfect *esse*, since nothing operates except insofar as it is a being in actuality. Therefore, since the soul does not have perfect *esse* when it is separated from the body—just as no part at all is perfect when it is separated from its whole—it seems that the soul cannot be blessed without the body.

Objection 3: Beatitude is man's perfection. But the soul is not a man without the body. Therefore, beatitude cannot exist in the soul without the body.

Objection 4: According to the Philosopher in *Ethics* 7, the operation of happiness that beatitude consists in is unimpeded. But a separated soul's operation is impeded, since, as Augustine says in *Super Genesim ad Litteram* 12, "There is in the soul a certain desire to rule the body, and it is in a sense held back by this desire from moving with full force (*tota intentione*) toward the highest heaven," that is, toward seeing God's essence. Therefore, the soul cannot be blessed without the body.

Objection 5: Beatitude is a sufficient good and so puts desire to rest. But this good cannot belong to a separated soul, since, as Augustine says, it still desires to be united to the body. Therefore, a soul that is separated from its body cannot be blessed.

Objection 6: A man is equal in beatitude to the angels. But as Augustine says, the soul without the body is not equal to the angels. Therefore, the soul without the body is not blessed.

But contrary to this: Apocalypse 14:13 says, "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord."

I respond: There are two sorts of beatitude: the one, which is had in this life, is imperfect, and the other, which consists in the act of seeing God, is perfect.

Now it is clear that for the sort of beatitude that belongs to this life the body is necessarily required. For the beatitude that belongs to this life is an operation of the intellect, either the speculative intellect or the practical intellect. But in this life the intellect's operation cannot exist without phantasms, which, as was established in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 84, aa. 6-7), exist only in a corporeal organ. And so the beatitude that can be had in this life depends in some way on the body.

But as regards the perfect beatitude that consists in the act of seeing God, some have claimed that this beatitude cannot come to the soul when it exists without the body, and they assert that the souls of the saints, which are separated from their bodies, do not arrive at this beatitude until Judgment Day, when they regain their bodies.

But it is clear both from authority and from reason that this claim is false.

It is clear from authority because in 2 Corinthians 5:6 the Apostle says, “As long as we remain in the body, we are wandering away from the Lord.” And he shows the reason for this wandering when he adds, “For we walk by faith and not by sight (*per fidem et non per speciem*).” From this it is clear that as long as someone walks by faith and not by sight, lacking the vision of God’s essence, he is not yet present to God. By contrast, the souls of the saints, separated from their bodies, are present to God; this is why he adds, “But we are confident and have a good intention to wander away from the body and to be present to the Lord.” Hence, it is clear that the souls of the saints, separated from their bodies, walk by sight and see God’s essence, wherein lies true beatitude.

This same point is also clear from reason. For the intellect needs the body for its operation only because of the phantasms, in which it perceives intelligible truth; this was explained in the First Part (ST 1, q. 84, a. 7). But as was also explained in the First Part (ST 1, q. 12, a. 3), it is obvious that God’s essence cannot be seen through phantasms. Hence, since man’s perfect beatitude consists in seeing God’s essence, man’s perfect beatitude does not depend on the body. Thus, the soul can be blessed without the body.

But notice that there are two ways in which something pertains to a thing’s perfection. The first way is by constituting that thing’s *essence*, in the way that the soul is required for man’s perfection. In a second way, what is required for a thing’s perfection is what pertains to its *well-being* (*ad bene esse eius*), in the way that bodily attractiveness or quickness of wit pertains to a man’s perfection.

Therefore, even though the body is irrelevant to the perfection of human beatitude in the first way, it is nonetheless relevant in the second way. For since a thing’s operation depends on its nature, when the soul is more perfect in its own nature, it will to that extent have more perfectly the proper operation in which happiness (*felicitas*) consists. Hence, in *Super Genesim ad Litteram* 12, having asked “whether this highest beatitude can be bestowed on the spirits of the dead without their bodies,” Augustine replies, “They cannot see the incommutable substance in the way that the holy angels do, either for some other more hidden reason or because they have a natural desire to rule their bodies.”

Reply to objection 1: Beatitude is the perfection of the soul on the part of its intellect, with respect to which the soul transcends the body’s organs, whereas beatitude is not the perfection of the soul insofar as the soul is the natural form of the body. And so the first sort of perfection of nature, in accord with which beatitude befits the soul, remains—even though the sort of perfection of nature it has insofar as it is the form of the body does not remain.

Reply to objection 2: The soul is related to its *esse* in a way different from the way in which other parts are related to their *esse*.

For the *esse* of a whole does not belong to any of its parts; hence, when a whole is destroyed, either (a) the parts cease to exist altogether, in the way that the parts of an animal cease to exist when the animal is destroyed, or (b) if the parts remain, then they have a different *esse* in actuality, in the way that a part of a line has an *esse* different from that of the line as a whole.

By contrast, the *esse* of the composite remains with the human soul after the destruction of the body—and this because the *esse* of the form is the same as the *esse* of the matter, and this *esse* is the *esse* of the composite. But as was shown in the First Part (ST 1, q. 75, a. 2), the soul subsists in its own *esse*. Hence, it follows that after its separation from the body it still has its complete (*perfectum*) *esse* and so it can have its perfect operation—even though it does not have the complete nature of the species (*licet non habeat perfectam naturam speciei*).

Reply to objection 3: Man’s beatitude has to do with the intellect, and so as long as the intellect

remains, beatitude can exist within it. Similarly, an Ethiopian's teeth, with respect to which the Ethiopian is said to be white, can be white even after they have been extracted.

Reply to objection 4: There are two ways in which one thing is impeded by another.

The first way is by *contrariety*, in the way that coldness impedes the action of heat, and this sort of impediment to an operation is incompatible with happiness.

The second way is in the manner of a *shortage* (*per modum cuiusdam defectus*), viz., when the impeded thing does not have everything that is required for its complete perfection (*ad omnimodam sui perfectionem*). This sort of impediment to an operation is not incompatible with happiness, though it is incompatible with its complete perfection. This is the sense in which being separated from the body is said to hold the soul back "from moving with full force" toward seeing God's essence. For the soul desires to enjoy God in such a way that the enjoyment itself, as is possible, also overflows into the body (*dirivetur ad corpus per redundantiam*). And so as long as the soul itself enjoys God in the absence of the body, its desire is put to rest in what it has, yet in such a way that it nonetheless still wants its own body to participate in it.

Reply to objection 5: The separated soul's desire is completely put to rest as regards what is desired, since it has that which suffices for its own desire. But it is not totally at rest as regards the one who has the desire, since it does not possess the relevant good in every way in which it wants to possess it. And so, when it regains its body, beatitude increases in its extent, though not in its intensity (*beatitudo crescit non intensive sed extensive*).

Reply to objection 6: What he says in that place, viz., that "the spirits of the dead do not see God in the way that the angels do," should not be taken to imply a *quantitative* inequality (*non est intelligendum secundum inaequalitatem quantitatis*), since even now some of the souls of the blessed have been assumed into the higher orders of angels and see God more clearly than the lower angels do (cf. ST 1, q. 108, a. 8). Rather, it implies a *proportional* inequality (*secundum inaequalitatem proportionis*), since the angels, even the lowest ones, have the entire perfection of beatitude that they are ever going to have, whereas this is not the case with the separated souls of the saints.

Article 6

Is the perfection of the body required for beatitude?

It seems that the perfection of the body is not required for man's perfect beatitude:

Objection 1: The perfection of the body is a certain corporeal good. But it was shown above (q. 2) that beatitude does not lie in corporeal goods. Therefore, it is not the case that some perfect disposition on the part of the body is required for man's beatitude.

Objection 2: As has been shown (q. 3, a. 8), man's beatitude consists in the act of seeing God's essence. But as has been explained (a. 5), the body does not contribute anything to this operation. Therefore, there is no sort of disposition on the part of the body that is required for beatitude.

Objection 3: The more abstracted the intellect is from the body, the more perfectly it understands. But beatitude consists in the most perfect possible operation of the intellect. Therefore, the soul has to be abstracted from the body in every way. Therefore, there is no sort of disposition on the part of the body that is in any sense required for beatitude.

But contrary to this: Beatitude is the reward for virtue; hence John 13:17 says, "You shall be blessed if you do these things." But what is promised to the saints as a reward is not just seeing God and delighting in Him, but also a certain good disposition on the part of the body. For the last chapter of Isaiah, verse 14, says, "You will see, and your heart will rejoice, and your bones will flourish like an herb." Therefore, a good disposition on the part of the body is required for beatitude.

I respond: If we are talking about the sort of human beatitude that can be had in this life, then it is clear that a good disposition on the part of the body is necessarily required for it. For according to the Philosopher, this sort of beatitude consists in the operation of perfect virtue. But it is obvious that a man can be impeded in every sort of virtuous operation by bodily infirmities (*per invaletudinem corporis*).

On the other hand, if we are talking about perfect beatitude, some have claimed that no particular disposition of the body is required for beatitude; in fact, they have claimed that what is required for beatitude is that the soul should be altogether separated from the body. Hence, in *De Civitate Dei* 22 Augustine quotes Porphyry as saying that “in order for the soul to be blessed, it must flee from all bodies.”

But this is wrong. For since it is natural for the soul to be united to its body, it cannot be the case that the soul’s perfection excludes the body’s natural perfection.

And so one should reply that for beatitude that is perfect in every way, a perfect disposition on the part of the body is required both as an antecedent and as a consequence.

It is required as an *antecedent* because, as Augustine says in *Super Genesim ad Litteram* 12, “If the body is such that it is difficult and burdensome to rule—e.g., flesh that is corrupting and burdening the soul—then the mind is turned away from the vision that belongs to the highest heaven.” Hence, he concludes that since the body will be a spiritual body and no longer an animal body, a man will at that point be equal to the angels, and what was a burden to him will be to his glory.

On the other hand, it is required as a *consequence* because there will be an overflow of the soul’s beatitude into the body, so that the body itself will have its own perfection. Hence, in the letter *Ad Dioscorum* Augustine says, “God made the soul with such a potent nature that the vigor of incorruption overflows from its fullness of beatitude into the lower nature.”

Reply to objection 1: Beatitude does not lie in a corporeal good in the sense that such a good is the object of beatitude. But a corporeal good can make for a certain embellishment and perfection of beatitude.

Reply to objection 2: Even if the body does not contribute anything to the operation of the intellect by which God’s essence is seen, it could nonetheless impede that operation. And so the body’s perfection is required in order that it not impede the mind from being elevated.

Reply to objection 3: What is required for a perfect operation on the part of the intellect is an abstraction from this corruptible body, which burdens the soul, but not from the spiritual body, which will be totally subject to the spirit. This will be discussed in the Third Part of this work.

Article 7

Are exterior goods required for beatitude?

It seems that even exterior goods are required for beatitude:

Objection 1: What is promised to the saints as a reward is relevant to beatitude. But the saints are promised exterior goods such as food and drink, riches and a kingdom (*regnum*); for Luke 22:30 says, “... that you may eat and drink at my table in my kingdom,” and Matthew 6:20 says, “Lay up treasures for yourselves in heaven,” and Matthew 25:34 says, “Come, blessed of my Father, possess the kingdom.” Therefore, exterior goods are required for beatitude.

Objection 2: According to Boethius in *De Consolatione Philosophiae* 3, beatitude is “a state made perfect by the aggregation of all goods.” But as Augustine says, exterior goods are human goods, even if they are the least among them. Therefore, even they are required for beatitude.

Objection 3: Matthew 5:12 says, “Your reward is great in heaven.” But ‘to be in heaven’ signifies being in a place. Therefore, at least an exterior place is required for beatitude.

But contrary to this: Psalm 72:25 says, “For what have I in heaven? And, besides You, what do I desire upon earth?”—as if to say, I desire nothing other than what follows [in verse 28]: “It is good for me to adhere to God.” Therefore, no other exterior thing is required for beatitude.

I respond: For the sort of imperfect beatitude that can be had in this life exterior goods are required, not in the sense that they are part of the essence of beatitude, but in the sense that they are instruments serving beatitude, which, as *Ethics* 1 says, consists in the operation of virtue. For in this life a man needs bodily necessities both for the operation of contemplative virtue and for the operation of active virtue. For the latter, many other things are required as well, by means of which a man might perform the works of active virtue.

However, goods of this sort are not required in any way for the perfect beatitude that consists in seeing God. The reason for this is that all exterior goods of the sort in question are either required for sustaining the animal body, or else they are required for certain operations which we carry out by means of the animal body and which are appropriate for human life. By contrast, the perfect beatitude that consists in seeing God will exist either in a soul without a body or else in a soul united to a body that is spiritual and no longer animal. And so exterior goods of the sort in question are not required in any way for this sort of beatitude, since such goods are ordered toward animal life.

Moreover, as is clear from what has been said (q. 3, a. 5), in this life it is contemplative happiness, rather than active happiness, that comes closer to a likeness of perfect beatitude, given that it is more similar to God. This is why, as *Ethics* 10 says, contemplative happiness stands in less need of bodily goods of this sort.

Reply to objection 1: All these corporeal promises that are contained in Sacred Scripture are to be understood metaphorically, since in the Scriptures spiritual things are usually designated through corporeal things, so that, as Gregory puts it in one of his homilies, “from the things we know, we rise up to desire what is unknown.” For instance, ‘food’ and ‘drink’ stand for the delight of beatitude, ‘riches’ stands for the sufficiency by which God will suffice for man, and ‘kingdom’ stands for a man’s being lifted up to union with God.

Reply to objection 2: The goods in question, which serve animal life, do not belong to the spiritual life in which perfect beatitude consists. And yet within that beatitude there will be a collection of all goods, since whatever good is found in those things is such that all of it will be had in the source of all goods.

Reply to objection 3: According to Augustine in *De Sermonibus Domini in Monte*, it is not being asserted that the reward of the saints exists in the corporeal heavens; rather, ‘heaven’ means the height of spiritual goods.

Still, a corporeal place, viz., the empyrean heaven, will be present to the blessed, not because beatitude demands it, but in keeping with a certain fittingness and suitability.

Article 8

Are friends necessary for beatitude?

It seems that friends are necessary for beatitude:

Objection 1: In the Scriptures our future beatitude is often designated by the name ‘glory’. But glory consists in a man’s good being brought to the attention of many. Therefore, the company of friends (*societas amicorum*) is required for beatitude.

Objection 2: Boethius says, “There is no good such that it is delightful (*iucunda*) to possess it without company (*sine consortio*).” But delight (*delectatio*) is required for beatitude. Therefore, the company of friends is likewise required.

Objection 3: Charity is perfected in beatitude. But charity extends to loving God and neighbor. Therefore, it seems that the company of friends is required for beatitude.

But contrary to this: Wisdom 7:11 says, “All good things have come to me together with her,” i.e., together with divine wisdom, which consists in contemplating God. And so nothing else is required for beatitude.

I respond: If we are talking about the happiness (*felicitas*) that belongs to the present life, then, as the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 9, the happy man needs friends—not, to be sure, for the sake of their usefulness, since he is self-sufficient (*sibi sufficiens*); nor for the sake of pleasure, since he has within himself perfect delight in the operation of virtue; but instead for the sake of good action, so that, namely, he might do good to them, delight in seeing them do good, and be aided by them in doing good. For a man needs the assistance of friends in order to do well, both in the works of the active life and in the works of the contemplative life.

On the other hand, if we are talking about the perfect beatitude that will exist in heaven (*in patria*), then the company of friends is not necessarily required for beatitude, since a man has the entire fullness of his perfection in God.

However, the company of friends does make for the well-being of beatitude. Hence, in *Super Genesim ad Litteram* 8 Augustine says, “In order to be blessed, spiritual creatures are aided intrinsically only by the creator’s eternity, truth, and charity. However, extrinsically—if they should be said to be aided—they are perhaps aided by just one thing, viz., by seeing one another and rejoicing over their fellowship in God.”

Reply to objection 1: The glory that is essential to beatitude is that which a man has in the eyes of God and not in the eyes of men.

Reply to objection 2: This passage applies when what one has in the relevant good is not fully sufficient. But this cannot be said in the case under discussion, since in God a man has enough of every good.

Reply to objection 3: The perfection of charity is essential to beatitude with respect to loving God, but not with respect to loving one’s neighbor. Hence, if there were just one soul enjoying God, then he would be blessed even without having a neighbor to love.

However, if one assumes that a neighbor is present, then love of that neighbor follows from loving God perfectly. Hence, friendship is related concomitantly, as it were, to perfect beatitude.

QUESTION 5

The Attainment of Beatitude

Next we have to consider the attainment itself of beatitude. And on this topic there are eight questions: (1) Can a man attain beatitude? (2) Can one man be more blessed than another? (3) Can a man have beatitude in this life? (4) Can beatitude once had be lost? (5) Can a man acquire beatitude by means of his natural powers? (6) Can a man attain beatitude through the action of some higher creature? (7) Are some works required of a man in order for the man to obtain beatitude from God? (8) Does every man desire beatitude?

Article 1

Can a man acquire beatitude?

It seems that a man cannot acquire beatitude:

Objection 1: As is clear from Dionysius in many places in *De Divinis Nominibus*, just as a rational nature is higher than a sentient nature, so an intellectual nature is higher than a rational nature. But brute animals, which have only a sentient nature, cannot arrive at a rational nature's end. Therefore, neither can man, who has a rational nature, arrive at an intellectual nature's end, i.e., beatitude.

Objection 2: Genuine beatitude consists in seeing God, who is pure truth. But it is connatural to a man to see truth in material things; hence, as *De Anima* 3 says, "He understands intelligible species in phantasms." Therefore, man cannot arrive at beatitude.

Objection 3: Beatitude consists in acquiring the highest good. But one cannot arrive at the highest point without passing through the middle. Therefore, since in the middle between God and human nature there is angelic nature, which man cannot transcend, it seems that man cannot acquire beatitude.

But contrary to this: Psalm 93:12 says, "Blessed the man whom you shall instruct, O Lord."

I respond: 'Beatitude' names the acquisition of the perfect good. Therefore, whoever has a capacity for the perfect good (*est capax perfecti boni*) can arrive at beatitude. But it is clear that a man has a capacity for the perfect good, since it is the case both that his intellect is able to apprehend a universal and perfect good and that his will is able to desire that good. And so a man is able to acquire beatitude.

The same thing is also clear from the fact, established in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 12, a. 1), that a man has the capacity to see God's essence, and we have explained (q. 3, a. 8) that this vision is what man's perfect beatitude consists in.

Reply to objection 1: A rational nature exceeds a sentient nature in a way different from that in which an intellectual nature exceeds a rational nature.

For a rational nature exceeds a sentient nature with respect to *the object of cognition*, since there is no way in which a sensory power can have a cognition of a universal, which is what reason has cognition of.

By contrast, an intellectual nature exceeds a rational nature with respect to *the way it has a cognition* of the very same intelligible truth; for as is clear from what was said in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 58, a. 3 and q. 79, a. 8), an intellectual nature apprehends immediately the truth which a rational nature attains to [only] through reason's inquiry. And so it is through a certain movement that reason attains to what the intellect apprehends. Hence, a rational nature is able to attain beatitude, which is the perfection of an intellectual nature, but in a way different from that in which the angels attain it. For the angels attained to beatitude immediately after the beginning of their existence (*statim post principium suae conditionis*), whereas men arrive at beatitude over time (*per tempus*). By contrast, a sentient nature cannot attain this end in any way at all.

Reply to objection 2: The mode of knowing intelligible truth through phantasms is connatural to man within the state of the present life. But as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 89), after the

present life, man has a different connatural mode of cognition.

Reply to objection 3: Man cannot transcend the angels in the level of his nature, i.e., so as to be naturally higher than they are. Nevertheless, he is able to transcend them through the operation of his intellect, when he understands that there is something beyond the angels which beatifies man and which is such that when a man perfectly attains it, he will be perfectly blessed.

Article 2

Can one man be more blessed than another?

It seems that one man cannot be more blessed than another:

Objection 1: As the Philosopher says in *Ethics* 1, beatitude is “the reward for virtue.” But an equal reward is given to everyone for the works of virtue. For Matthew 20:10 says that all who worked in the vineyard “received every man a denarius,” since, as Gregory puts it, “They obtained the equal payment of eternal life.” Therefore, one will not be more blessed than another.

Objection 2: Beatitude is the highest good. But there cannot be anything greater (*maius*) than what is highest. Therefore, any one man’s beatitude is such that there cannot be a beatitude greater than it.

Objection 3: Since beatitude is a perfect and sufficient good, it puts a man’s desire to rest. But a desire is not put to rest if there is some good lacking that could be supplied. But if there is nothing lacking that could be supplied, then there could not be any other good that is greater. Therefore, either the man is not blessed or, if he is blessed, then there cannot be another greater beatitude.

But contrary to this: John 14:2 says, “In my Father’s house there are many mansions”—by which, as Augustine puts it, “we are to understand different values of merit (*diversae meritorum dignitates*) in eternal life.” But the value of eternal life that is given for merits is beatitude itself. Therefore, there are different levels of beatitude and not an equal beatitude for everyone.

I respond: As was explained above (q. 1, a. 8 and q. 2, a. 7), there are two things included in the concept of beatitude, viz., (a) the ultimate end itself, which is the highest good, and (b) the acquisition or enjoyment of that good.

Thus, as regards the good itself that is the object and the cause of beatitude, one beatitude cannot be greater than another, since there is only one highest good, viz., God, who is such that men are blessed in enjoying Him.

However, as regards the acquisition or enjoyment of this good, one man can be more blessed than another, since one is more blessed to the extent that this good is enjoyed more. Now someone is able to enjoy God more perfectly than another by the fact that he is better disposed or ordered toward enjoying Him; accordingly, the one can be more blessed than the other.

Reply to objection 1: The sameness of the denarius (*unitas denarii*) signifies the oneness of beatitude on the part of the object. On the other hand, the diversity of the mansions signifies the diversity of beatitude in accord with the different levels of enjoyment.

Reply to objection 2: Beatitude is called the highest good insofar as it is the perfect possession of or enjoyment of the highest good.

Reply to objection 3: No one who is blessed is lacking in any good that is to be desired, since he has the infinite good itself, which, as Augustine puts it, is “the good of every good.” But someone is said to be more blessed than another because of the diverse ways of participating in that same good.

Moreover, the addition of other goods does not increase beatitude; hence, in *Confessiones* 5 Augustine says, “He who knows you and other things as well is not more blessed because of those other things, but is blessed because of you alone.”

Article 3

Can beatitude be had in this life?

It seems that beatitude can be had in this life:

Objection 1: Psalm 118:1 says, “Blessed are the undefiled on the way (*immaculati in via*), who walk in the law of the Lord.” But this is something that happens in the present life. Therefore, someone can be blessed in this life.

Objection 2: An imperfect participation in the highest good does not rule out beatitude; otherwise, it would not be the case that one man can be more blessed than another. But in this life men are able to participate in the highest good by knowing and loving God, albeit imperfectly. Therefore, a man can be blessed in this life.

Objection 3: What is asserted by the many (*a pluribus*) cannot be totally false; for what occurs in most cases appears to be natural, and nature does not totally fail. But there are many who claim that there is beatitude in this life, as is clear from Psalm 143:15, “They have called the people blessed who have these things,” viz, the goods of the present life. Therefore, someone can be blessed in this life.

But contrary to this: Job 14:1 says, “Man born of woman, living a short time, is filled with many miseries.” But beatitude excludes misery. Therefore, a man cannot be blessed in this life.

I respond: A sort of participation in beatitude can be had in this life, but perfect and genuine beatitude cannot be had in this life.

There are two possible ways to think about this:

The first way is derived from *the general concept of beatitude*. For since beatitude is “a perfect and sufficient good,” it excludes every evil and fulfills every desire.

But in this life it is impossible for every evil to be excluded. For as Augustine diligently discusses in detail in *De Civitate Dei* 19, the present life is subject to many evils that cannot be avoided: ignorance on the part of the intellect, disordered affection on the part of the appetite, and numerous afflictions (*multiplicibus poenalitibus*) on the part of the body.

Similarly, in this life the desire for the good cannot be fully satisfied. For a man naturally desires that the good he possesses should be permanent. But the goods of the present life are transitory, since even life itself passes away, despite the fact that we naturally desire it and want it to endure forever; for man naturally recoils from death.

Therefore, it is impossible that genuine beatitude should be had in this life.

The second way considers *what beatitude consists in specifically*, viz., seeing God’s essence, which, as was shown in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 12, a. 2), cannot come to a man in this life.

From these considerations it is clear that no one can acquire genuine and perfect beatitude in this life.

Reply to objection 1: Some are called blessed in this life either (a) because of their hope of attaining beatitude in a future life—this according to Romans 8:24 (“We are saved by hope”)—or (b) because of a participation in beatitude that comes from some sort of enjoyment of the highest good.

Reply to objection 2: There are two ways in which a participation in beatitude can be imperfect:

In one way, on the part of the *object of beatitude*, which is not seen with respect to its essence; and this sort of participation undermines the concept of genuine beatitude.

In the second way, the participation can be imperfect on the part of *the one participating*, who indeed attains the very object of beatitude in Himself, viz. God, but does so imperfectly in comparison with the mode in which God enjoys Himself. This sort of imperfection does not destroy the true concept of beatitude. For since, as was explained above (q. 3, a. 2), beatitude is a certain operation, the true concept of beatitude is taken from the object, which gives the act its species, and not from the subject.

Reply to objection 3: It is because of a likeness to genuine beatitude that men think there is some sort of beatitude in this life. And so they are not completely mistaken in thinking this.

Article 4

Can beatitude be lost?

It seems that beatitude can be lost:

Objection 1: Beatitude is a certain perfection. But every perfection exists in the perfectible thing in accord with the mode of that thing (*secundum modum ipsius*). Therefore, since man is mutable by his nature, it seems that beatitude is participated in by a man in a mutable way. And so it seems that a man can lose beatitude.

Objection 2: Beatitude consists in an action of the intellect, and the intellect is subject to the will. But the will is open to opposites (*se habet ad opposita*). Therefore, it seems that the will could desist from the operation by which a man is beatified, and in this way the man would cease to be blessed.

Objection 3: Corresponding to a beginning (*principium*) there is an ending (*finis*). But a man's beatitude has a beginning, since the man has not always been blessed. Therefore, it seems that his beatitude has an ending.

But contrary to this: Matthew 25:46 says of the just that "they shall go into life everlasting"—which, as has been explained (a. 2), is the beatitude of the saints. But what is eternal does not end (*non deficit*). Therefore, beatitude cannot be lost.

I respond: If we are talking about imperfect beatitude of the sort that can be had in this life, then in this sense beatitude can be lost.

This is obvious in the case of *contemplative* happiness, which is lost either (a) through forgetfulness, as when one's knowledge is corrupted by an illness, or (b) because of certain occupations by which someone is totally distracted from contemplation.

The same thing is also clear in the case of *active* happiness. For a man's will can change, so that he degenerates from virtue, in the operation of which happiness principally consists, into vice. On the other hand, even if virtue remains uncorrupted (*integra*), exterior changes can disturb this sort of beatitude insofar as they pose obstacles to many acts of the virtues. However, exterior changes cannot totally destroy this sort of beatitude, since the operation of a virtue still remains as long as a man withstands these adversities in a praiseworthy way.

Moreover, it is because the beatitude of this life can be lost—something which seems contrary to the concept of beatitude—that in *Ethics* 1 the Philosopher says that in this life some are blessed, not absolutely speaking, but "as men" whose nature is subject to change.

By contrast, if we are talking about the perfect beatitude which one looks forward to after this life, then notice that Origen, following the error of certain Platonists, claimed that a man can become unhappy after having had ultimate beatitude.

But there are two ways in which to see that this is obviously false.

First, from *the general concept of beatitude (ex ipsa communi ratione beatitudinis)*. For since beatitude itself is a perfect and sufficient good, it must put a man's desire to rest and exclude all evil. But a man naturally desires to hold on to the good that he has and to have a guarantee that he will keep it (*eius retinendi obtineat securitatem*); otherwise, he will necessarily be troubled by the fear of losing it or by sadness at the certainty that he will lose it. Therefore, what is required for genuine beatitude is that a man have the fixed opinion that he will never lose the good that he has. If this opinion is true, it follows that he will never lose beatitude. On the other hand, if it is false, then this very fact is an evil, viz., to have a false opinion, since, as *Ethics* 6 says, falsehood is bad for the intellect in the same way that truth is

its good. Therefore, he will not have been truly blessed (*beatus*) if some evil exists in him.

Second, the same point is clear from a consideration of *the specific concept of beatitude (ratio beatitudinis in speciali)*. For it was shown above (q. 3, a.8) that a man's perfect beatitude consists in seeing God's essence. But it is impossible for anyone who is seeing God's essence to will not to see it. For every good that someone wills not to have is such that either (a) it is insufficient and something more sufficient is being sought after in its place, or (b) there is something unwelcome (*incommodum*) connected with it and because of this it comes to be disliked (*propter quod in fastidium venit*). But the vision of God's essence fills the soul with every good, since it unites the soul to the font of all goodness; hence, Psalm 16:15 says, "I shall be satisfied when Your glory appears," and Wisdom 7:11 says, "All good things came to me together with her," viz., with the contemplation of wisdom. Similarly, the vision of God does not have anything unwelcome adjoined to it; for Wisdom 8:16 says of the contemplation of wisdom, "Her conversation has no bitterness, nor does her company have any tedium."

So, then, it is clear that someone who is blessed cannot give up beatitude by his own will (*propria voluntate non potest beatitudinem deserere*).

Similarly, he cannot lose it by having God take it away from him (*Deo subtrahente*). For since taking away beatitude would constitute a punishment, it could not come from God, the just judge, except for some sin; but someone who is seeing God's essence cannot fall into sin, since, as was shown above (q. 4, a. 4), rectitude of will necessarily follows upon seeing God's essence.

Again, neither could any other agent take away beatitude. For a mind conjoined to God is elevated above all other things, and so no other agent can cut it off from that union.

Hence, it is clearly absurd that a man should pass from beatitude to misery, or from misery back to beatitude, over the changing course of time (*per quasdam alternationes temporum*). For there cannot be temporal changes of this sort except with respect to things that are subject to time and change (*nisi circa ea quae subiacent tempori et motui*).

Reply to objection 1: Beatitude is a consummate perfection which excludes every defect from the one who is blessed. And so beatitude comes without mutability to the one who has it, once it is brought about by God's power, which lifts a man up to participation in an eternity that transcends all change.

Reply to objection 2: The will is open to opposites in the case of those things that are ordered toward an end, but it is ordered toward its ultimate end by natural necessity. This is clear from the fact that a man is not able not to will to be blessed (*homo not potest non velle esse beatus*).

Reply to objection 3: Beatitude has a beginning because of the nature (*conditio*) of the one who participates in it; but it lacks an ending because of the nature of the good which is such that participation in it makes one blessed. Hence, the beginning of beatitude derives from one thing, and that fact that it lacks an ending derives from something else.

Article 5

Is a man able to attain beatitude by his own natural powers?

It seems that a man able is to attain beatitude by his own natural powers (*per sua naturalia*):

Objection 1: Nature is not deficient when it comes to necessities. But nothing is more necessary to a man than that by means of which he attains his ultimate end. Therefore, this is not lacking to human nature. Therefore, a man is able to attain beatitude by his own natural powers.

Objection 2: Since man is more noble than the non-rational creatures, he seems to be more self-sufficient (*sufficientior*). But non-rational creatures are able to attain their own ends by their own natural powers. Therefore, *a fortiori*, a man is able to attain beatitude through his own natural powers.

Objection 3: According to the Philosopher, beatitude is a perfect operation. But that which

initiates a thing is the same as that which brings it to perfection. Therefore, since the imperfect operation, which is, as it were, the beginning (*principium*) in the case of human operations, is subject to a man's natural power, by means of which he is the master of his own acts, it seems that he is able to attain the perfect operation, i.e., beatitude, through his own natural power.

But contrary to this: A man is naturally the principle of his own acts through his intellect and his will. But the ultimate beatitude prepared for the saints exceeds the human intellect and will; for 1 Corinthians 2:9 says, "Eye has not seen, nor ear heard, nor has it entered into the heart of man, what things God has prepared for those who love Him." Therefore, a man cannot attain beatitude by his own natural powers.

I respond: Through his own natural powers a man can acquire the imperfect beatitude that can be had in this life, in the sense that through his own natural powers he can likewise acquire virtue, the operation of which this beatitude consists in. This will be explained below (q. 63).

However, as was explained above (q. 3, a. 8), man's perfect beatitude consists in seeing God's essence. And as was shown in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 12, a. 4), seeing God through His essence lies not only beyond human nature, but also beyond every creature's nature. For any creature's natural cognition is in accord with the mode of its substance (*secundum modum substantiae suae*), in the sense in which the *Liber de Causis* says of an intelligence that "it has cognition of what is above it, and of what is below it, in accord with the mode of its substance (*secundum modum substantiae suae*).” But every cognition that is in accord with the mode of a created substance falls short of seeing God's essence, which infinitely surpasses every created substance. Hence, neither man nor any other creature can attain ultimate beatitude through his own natural powers.

Reply to objection 1: Just as nature has not failed man when it comes to necessities even though it has not given him weapons and hides as it has to other animals—for nature has given man reason and hands, by which he is able to provide these things for himself—so, too, nature has not failed man when it comes to necessities even though it has not given him any principle by which he can attain beatitude. For this was impossible. However, it did give him free choice, by which he would be able to turn toward God, who would make him blessed. For as *Ethics* 3 says, what we can do through our friends is such that we can in some sense do it through ourselves.

Reply to objection 2: As the Philosopher says in *De Caelo* 2, a nature that can attain the perfect good, even though it needs exterior help to do this, is more noble than a nature that cannot attain the perfect good, but instead attains some imperfect good, even though it does not need exterior help to do this. In the same way, someone who is able to attain perfect health, even though this is through the help of medicine, is better disposed toward health than is someone who is able only to attain imperfect health without the help of medicine. And so a rational creature, who is able to attain the perfect good of beatitude, though he needs God's help to do this, is more perfect than a non-rational creature, which does not have a capacity for this sort of good, but instead attains some imperfect good by the power of its own nature.

Reply to objection 3: When what is imperfect and what is perfect belong to the same species, they can be caused by the same power. However, this is not necessary if they belong to different species; for it is not the case that whatever can cause a given disposition in matter can confer the ultimate perfection. But the imperfect operation that is subject to man's natural power does not belong to the same species as the perfect operation that constitutes man's beatitude, since the species of the operation depends on the object. Hence, the argument does not go through (*ratio non sequitur*).

Article 6

Can a man be made blessed through the action of a higher creature, viz., an angel?

It seems that a man can be made blessed through the action of a higher creature, viz., an angel:

Objection 1: There are two orderings found among things: (a) the ordering of the parts of the universe to one another, and (b) the ordering of the universe as a whole to a good that lies outside the universe. As *Metaphysics* 12 says, the first of these orderings is itself ordered to the second as to its end, in the way that the ordering of the parts of an army to one another is for the sake of the ordering of the whole army to its leader. But as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, 109, a. 2), the ordering of the parts of the universe to one another involves higher creatures acting on lower creatures, whereas beatitude consists in man's being ordered to a good that lies outside the universe, viz., God. Therefore, it is through the action of a higher creature, viz., an angel, on a man that the man is made blessed.

Objection 2: What is such-and-such in potentiality can be brought to actuality through that which is such-and-such in actuality; for instance, what is hot in potentiality is made hot in actuality through that which is hot in actuality. But man is blessed in potentiality. Therefore, he can be made blessed in actuality by an angel who is blessed in actuality.

Objection 3: As was explained above (q. 3, a. 4), beatitude consists in an operation of the intellect. But as was established in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 111, a. 1), an angel can illuminate a man's intellect. Therefore, an angel can make a man blessed.

But contrary to this: Psalm 83:12 says, "The Lord will give grace and glory."

I respond: Since every creature is subject to the laws of nature in the sense of having limited power and action, what exceeds created nature cannot be brought about by the power of any creature. And so if something that lies beyond nature (*est super naturam*) has to be brought about, this is done immediately by God—e.g., resuscitating the dead, giving sight to the blind, and other things of this sort. But it has been shown (a. 5) that beatitude is a good that exceeds created nature. Hence, it is impossible for beatitude to be conferred through the action of any creature; instead, if we are talking about perfect beatitude, a man is made blessed by God acting alone.

On the other hand, if we are talking about imperfect beatitude, then the explanation that applies to it is the same as the explanation that applies to virtue, the action of which imperfect beatitude consists in.

Reply to objection 1: What happens in most of the cases involving ordered active powers is that it is the highest power's role to bring a thing to its ultimate end, whereas the lower powers assist in the attainment of this ultimate end by conferring dispositions (*disponendo*); for instance, the use of a ship, for the sake of which the ship itself is made, pertains to the art of navigation, which presides over the art of shipbuilding. So, then, likewise in the case of the ordering of the universe, in attaining to beatitude a man is aided by the angels with respect to certain preliminaries by which he is disposed toward attaining to beatitude. But he attains the ultimate end itself through the first agent Himself, viz., God.

Reply to objection 2: When a form exists in something in actuality with perfect and natural *esse*, then it can be a principle for acting on another; for instance, a hot thing gives warmth through its heat. But if a form exists in something imperfectly and not with natural *esse*, then it cannot be a principle for communicating itself to another. For instance, the likeness of a color (*intentio coloris*) that exists in the pupil cannot make anything white. Again, not everything that is illuminated or heated can illuminate other things or make other things warm; otherwise, illuminating and heating would go on *ad infinitum*.

Now the light of glory through which God is seen exists in God perfectly with its natural *esse*, but in a creature it exists imperfectly and with assimilated or participated *esse*. Hence, no creature who is blessed can communicate his beatitude to another.

Reply to objection 3: As was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 106, a. 1), a beatified angel illuminates man's intellect, or even the intellect of a lower angel, with respect to certain ideas about

God's works, but not with respect to seeing God's essence. For in seeing His essence, all beatified creatures are illuminated directly by God.

Article 7

Are any human works required in order to obtain beatitude from God?

It seems that no human works are required in order to obtain beatitude from God:

Objection 1: Since God is an agent of infinite power, neither matter nor any disposition on the part of the matter is a prerequisite for His acting; instead, He can produce the whole immediately. But since, as has been explained (a. 6), a man's works are not required as an efficient cause of his own beatitude, they cannot be required for beatitude except as dispositions. Therefore, God, who does not need any dispositions for His acting, confers beatitude without any antecedent works.

Objection 2: Just as God is the direct source of beatitude (*auctor beatitudinis immediate*), so too He immediately establishes nature. But in the first establishment of nature, He produced creatures in the absence of any antecedent disposition or action on the part of any creature; instead, He instantly (*statim*) made each thing perfect in its species. Therefore, it seems that He confers beatitude on a man without any antecedent operations.

Objection 3: In Romans 4:6 the Apostle says that beatitude belongs to the man "on whom God confers justification without works." Therefore, no human works are required in order to obtain beatitude.

But contrary to this: John 13:17 says, "If you know these things, you will be blessed if you do them." Therefore, one arrives at beatitude through action.

I respond: As was explained above (q. 4, a. 4), rectitude of will is required for beatitude. For rectitude of will is nothing other than the will's being rightly ordered toward its ultimate end, and this is required for attaining to the ultimate end in the same way that the right sort of disposition on the part of the matter is required for its attaining to a form.

However, this does not show that some human operation has to precede a man's beatitude; for God could simultaneously (a) make a will tend in the right way toward the end and (b) make it attain that end—just as He sometimes simultaneously disposes the matter and induces the form.

Nevertheless, the order of God's wisdom dictates that it not happen this way. For as *De Caelo* 2 says, "Of those things that have a perfect good, some have it with no movement, some have it with a single movement, and some have it with many movements."

Now to have the perfect good without movement is something that belongs to what has that good by nature (*naturaliter*). But to have beatitude naturally belongs solely to God. Hence, it is proper to God alone not to move toward beatitude through some antecedent operation.

On the other hand, since beatitude exceeds every created nature, no mere creature attains beatitude fittingly except by means of movement via an operation through which it tends toward beatitude. Now as was explained in the First Part (*ST* 1, q. 62, a. 5), an angel, who is higher in the order of nature than a man is, attained to beatitude in the order of God's wisdom with the single movement of a meritorious operation. Men, on the other hand, attain beatitude by means of many operational movements that are called *merits*. Hence, even according to the Philosopher, beatitude is the reward for virtuous operations.

Reply to objection 1: A man's operation is required antecedently for obtaining beatitude not because God's power to beatify someone is not sufficient, but so that the order among things might be preserved.

Reply to objection 2: The reason why God immediately produced the first creatures as perfect, without any antecedent disposition or operation on the part of a creature, was that He instituted the first

individuals of the various species in such a way that their natures would be propagated through them to their descendants. Similarly, it was because beatitude was to flow through Christ, who is God and man, to others—this according to Hebrews 2:10 (“... who had brought many children into glory”)—that His soul was made blessed immediately from the beginning of His conception without any antecedent meritorious operation.

However, this is peculiar to Christ. For His merit is what enables baptized children to obtain beatitude, even if they lack their own proper merits; for through baptism they have been made members of Christ.

Reply to objection 3: The Apostle is speaking here of the ‘beatitude of hope’, which is had through justifying grace and which is indeed not given because of antecedent works. For, unlike beatitude, it does not have nature of a terminus of movement, but is instead the beginning of a movement that tends toward beatitude.

Article 8

Does everyone desire beatitude?

It seems that not everyone desires beatitude:

Objection 1: No one can desire what he is ignorant of, since, as *De Anima* 3 says, it is an apprehended good that is the object of desire. But there are many who do not know what beatitude is—which, as Augustine explains in *De Trinitate* 13, is obvious from the fact that some have thought beatitude to lie in bodily pleasure, some in the mind’s virtue, and some in other things. Therefore, not everyone desires beatitude.

Objection 2: As has been explained (q. 3, a. 8), the essence of beatitude is seeing God’s essence. But some are of the opinion that it is impossible for God to be seen through His essence by a man, and so they do not desire it. Therefore, not all men desire beatitude.

Objection 3: In *De Trinitate* 13 Augustine says, “The blessed man is the one who has everything that he wills and who wills nothing badly.” But not everyone wills this very thing, since some men will certain things badly and yet will that they should will those things. Therefore, not everyone wills beatitude.

But contrary to this: In *De Trinitate* 13 Augustine says, “If he had said, ‘You all wish to be blessed, you do not wish to be wretched,’ then he would have said something that no one would fail to acknowledge in his own will.” Therefore, everyone desires to be blessed.

I respond: There are two possible ways to think of beatitude:

One way is in accord with *the general concept of beatitude (secundum communem rationem beatitudinis)*. Given this sense, it is necessary that every man should will beatitude. Now, as has been explained (aa. 3 and 4), the general concept of beatitude is that it is a perfect good. But since the good is the object of the will, someone’s perfect good is such that it totally satisfies his will. Hence, to desire beatitude is nothing other than to desire that one’s will should be satisfied—which everyone wants.

In the second way, we can speak of beatitude in accord with its *specific concept (secundum specialem rationem)*, i.e., with respect to what beatitude consists in. And given this sense, not everyone has a cognition of beatitude, since not everyone knows which thing is such that the general concept of beatitude applies to it. And, in this regard, consequently, not everyone wills beatitude.

Reply to objection 1: This makes clear the reply to the first objection.

Reply to objection 2: Since the act of will (*voluntas*) follows upon the intellect’s (i.e., reason’s) apprehension, it follows that just as it is possible for something to be the same in reality and yet diverse according to reason’s consideration of it, so too it is possible for something to be the same in reality and

yet to be desired in one way and not desired in another.

Thus, beatitude can be thought of under the concept of an ultimate and perfect good, which is the general concept of beatitude, and, as has been explained, given this sense, the will tends toward it naturally and by necessity. Beatitude can also be thought of in such a way as to include other specific considerations, either on the part of the operation itself, or on the part of the operative power, or on the part of the object. And when it is so considered, it is not necessarily the case that the will tends toward it.

Reply to objection 3: If the definition of beatitude that some have posited—viz., that the blessed man is he who has everything that he desires, or that the blessed man is he who is such that everything he hoped for has come true—is understood in a certain way, then it is a good and sufficient definition. But if it is understood in another way, then it is imperfect.

For if it is understood simply of all those things that a man wills *by a natural desire*, then it is true that he who has everything that he wills is blessed. For nothing except a perfect good, i.e., beatitude, satisfies a man's natural appetite.

By contrast, if the definition is understood of those things that a man wills *according to reason's apprehension*, then, in this sense, to have the things that the man wills pertains not to beatitude but more to wretchedness, to the extent that having things of this sort keeps a man from having everything that he naturally wills. In the same way, reason sometimes accepts as truths things that impede its cognition of the truth. And it is because of this consideration that Augustine adds to beatitude's perfection the idea that the man "wills nothing badly"—even though the first part of the definition, viz., that the blessed man is he who has everything that he wills, could suffice by itself if it were understood correctly,.